Cloud Engineer vs. Cloud Architect: What's the Difference?

Written by Indeed Editorial Team

Updated June 16, 2026

On this page



KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- A cloud engineer may often work closely with software developers, web developers and programmers to initiate design projects that support their companies.
- Cloud architects have similar roles to cloud engineers, but they deploy cloud-based applications according to client and business specifications rather than technical specifications.
- Due to the growing demand of technology solutions like cloud computing, there are many types of roles you may pursue in this area.

Cloud computing is becoming more common for accessing data and using applications in web-based environments. Due to the growing demand of technology solutions like cloud computing, there are many types of roles you may pursue in this area. Cloud engineering and cloud architecture are two fields to consider, though there are several distinctions between them.

In this article, we explore the differences between a cloud engineer and a cloud architect so you can determine the right career path for you.

Pro Tip: You can use Indeed Career Scout as your personal AI career coach to streamline every step of your search, from finding jobs and tailoring resumes to acing interviews and landing an offer.

Find your next job more quickly

Job seekers who use Indeed Career Scout are 38% more likely to get hired

Try Career Scout

Source: Indeed test data, US, May 2025, based on the average hires per apply

What is a cloud engineer?

Cloud engineers are the designers, creators and developers of cloud-based systems and solutions. They work in the information technology (IT) sector and focus on the development and integration of web-based applications on the cloud. A cloud engineer may often work closely with software developers, web developers and programmers to initiate design projects that support their companies.

Another key role of cloud engineers is their involvement in building and testing technical requirements within these cloud systems. They also work in leadership roles, where they oversee production processes, including establishing goals, setting timelines and aligning technical requirements with their project scopes.

Read more: What Is a Cloud Engineer?

Related jobs on Indeed

- Part-time jobs ›
- Full-time jobs ›
- Remote jobs ›
- Urgently hiring jobs ›

View more jobs on Indeed →

What is a cloud architect?

Cloud architects have similar roles to cloud engineers, but they deploy cloud-based applications according to client and business specifications rather than technical specifications. This means they're responsible for assessing the goals of both the business and the application to ensure all aspects are viable before development teams initiate the design.

Architects focus their work on just the frameworks and infrastructure of cloud-based applications, while engineers and developers handle coding, functionality and user experience (UX) and user interface (UI) testing. A cloud architect is also the team member responsible for redesigning the architecture of an existing system, especially when migrating applications to cloud-based frameworks.

Related: How To Become a Cloud Architect in 5 Steps (Plus Salary)

Search jobs and companies hiring now

Job title, keywords or company

Location

Search

Cloud engineer vs. cloud architect

Although both roles can have overlapping responsibilities, there are several key differences between a cloud engineer versus a cloud architect, including:

Education

While both cloud engineers and architects pursue degrees in similar fields, the education overall can differ between career paths. For instance, a cloud engineer may pursue a degree in computer engineering and IT principles, software development and computer programming. In contrast, cloud architects concentrate on learning the design aspects of cloud computing. They also focus some of their education on business management, administration and leadership training.

In addition, professionals who advance in either role can expect to see differences in post-graduate studies. For example, a cloud engineer might pursue a master's degree in computer engineering, whereas a cloud architect might pursue a master's degree in cloud computing.

Related: What Degree Do You Need To Be a Software Engineer?

Certification

Cloud engineers and architects work in technical roles that often benefit from certification. Although both fields can require additional credentials beyond a four-year degree, a cloud engineer often pursues engineering-related credentials in addition to technical certifications, while cloud architects concentrate on different certifications that demonstrate their cloud computing expertise. For instance, a cloud engineer might obtain the Fundamentals of Engineering (FE) and Licensed Professional Engineer (PE) certifications before earning technical certifications such as the Google Associate Cloud Engineer credential.

Conversely, cloud architects who pursue additional certifications may require more specialized credentials. For example, in contrast to a cloud engineer's Google-provided Associate Cloud Engineer certification, a cloud architect may obtain the Professional Cloud Architect credential from the same vendor. Additionally, employers may require different certifications for a cloud engineer versus a cloud architect. This makes it important to understand the requirements of the role you're pursuing.

Please note that the company mentioned in this article is not affiliated with Indeed.

Read more: Guide to Cloud Computing Certifications (Plus Benefits)

Skills

Another key difference between a cloud engineer and a cloud architect is the skill set each develops and applies in their role. Cloud engineers develop skills in the engineering, design and evaluation of cloud computing systems, and they generally use these skills in the development and technical capacities of cloud computing.

In contrast, a cloud architect develops skills in both cloud computing and business management, as their roles often require collaboration between internal management, company stakeholders, clients and the engineering and development teams. This means a cloud architect's skills go beyond the technical applications of designing cloud systems to include business administration and customer service.

Related: What Are Cloud Engineer Skills? Definitions and Examples

Job focus

Cloud engineers specialize in the technical aspects of designing and implementing cloud-based services, while a cloud architect concentrates on the overall framework and design. This means a cloud engineer is more likely to work on technical parameters like coding, deployment, testing and iteration. In contrast, a cloud architect is more likely to focus on the design integration of cloud solutions. A cloud

architect may draw up a framework or infrastructure for a new system and pass the design to a cloud engineer who initiates the development, integration and testing of the design.

Related: 16 Cloud Computer Careers (Plus Salary and Common Duties)

Organizational role

Although both cloud engineers and cloud architects often hold leadership positions, in larger work environments, a cloud architect may be in a more senior role. For instance, a large technology firm might employ a team of cloud technology professionals, including engineers and architects. In this situation, the cloud architect serves in a leadership capacity to help executives and C-level management make informed decisions.

As higher-level professionals in the firm make decisions and design specifications, architects collaborate with cloud engineers who initiate these plans within their teams. In this way, a cloud architect may hold a more senior role, while a cloud engineer may work under the supervision and direction of the architect.

Salary potential

Cloud engineers can expect a substantial salary range, averaging between $75,558 to $183,108 per year. A national average salary of $117,624 per year means you have the potential to earn a six-figure income depending on your location, level of experience and place of employment. While cloud engineering has the potential of a substantial income, cloud architects often earn more on average. An experienced cloud architect can see an average income between $92,747 to $193,042 per year, with the national average salary showing the potential to earn around $133,806 per year.

Related: Cloud Engineer Certifications To Consider (With FAQs)

For the most up-to-date salary information from Indeed, click on the links provided.



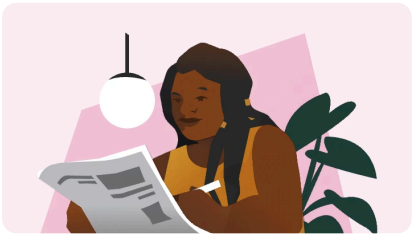
Show Transcript

Video: Resume Writing: Tips on How To Write a Standout Resume

Holl explains how to choose the best type and format of resume for your application, and how to maximize the impact of your resume bullet points

The information on this site is provided as a courtesy and for informational purposes only. Indeed is not a career or legal advisor and does not guarantee job interviews or offers.

Related Articles



Guide To Applying To Several Jobs at the Same Company



A Day in the Life of a Pilot (Plus Job Requirements)



"Am I Qualified?" (How To Know When You're Ready for a Role)

1 / 4

Explore more articles

17 Jobs That Require a Degree in Computer Engineering

16 Types of Traders (Plus Tips for Choosing a Trading Style)

How To Write an Email Asking for an Update (With 3 Examples)

25 Careers in Fitness (With Salaries)

What is Public Relations? What You Need To Know About a Career in PR

17 Common Job Scams and How To Protect Yourself

12 Free Email Account Providers and How To Choose One

Understanding the Advantages and Disadvantages of Employment-at-Will

What Does a Food Scientist Do? (And How To Become One)

Is It Better To Apply for Jobs in Person or Online?

How To Include Your High School Education on a Resume

Retail Operations: Definition, Functions and Job Opportunities

© 2026 Indeed